

Ben Jacobsen

Curriculum Vitae

📞 (505) 239-3413

✉ bjacobsen3@wisc.edu

🌐 ben-jacobsen.github.io

Education

- May 2027 **PhD, Computer Sciences**, *University of Wisconsin–Madison*, Madison, WI
(expected) Advisor: Kassem Fawaz
PhD Minor: Science and Technology Studies
- 2024 **MS, Computer Sciences**, *University of Wisconsin–Madison*, Madison, WI
- 2021 **BA, Mathematics**, *University of Arizona*, Tucson, AZ
Summa Cum Laude and Honors
- 2019 **AS, Mathematical Sciences**, *Central New Mexico Community College*,
Albuquerque, NM
With Highest Honors

Publications

Conference Publications

- 2026 **Ben Jacobsen**, Tomas Gonzalez, Gavin Brown, Kassem Fawaz, and Aaditya Ramdas. “Optimal Rates for Differentially Private Hypothesis Testing with E-values”. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2026)*.
- 2026 **Ben Jacobsen** and Kassem Fawaz. “Prediction with Expert Advice under Local Differential Privacy”. *International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR 2026)*.
- 2026 **Ben Jacobsen** and Nitin Kohli. “Privacy, Prediction, and Allocation”. *7th Symposium on Foundations of Responsible Computing (FORC 2026)*.
- 2025 **Ben Jacobsen** and Kassem Fawaz. “Private Continual Counting of Unbounded Streams”. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2025)*.

Journal Publications

- 2021 Markus Wallinger, **Ben Jacobsen**, Stephen Kobourov, and Martin Nöllenburg. “On the Readability of Abstract Set Visualizations”. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*.
- 2020 **Ben Jacobsen**, Markus Wallinger, Stephen Kobourov, and Martin Nöllenburg. “Metrosets: Visualizing Sets as Metro Maps”. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*.

Workshop Publications

- 2021 **Ben Jacobsen**, Sazzadur Rahaman, and Saumya Debray. “Optimization to the Rescue: Evading Binary Code Stylometry with Adversarial Use of Code Optimizations”. In: *Proceedings of the 2021 Research on offensive and defensive techniques in the Context of Man At The End (MATE) Attacks*, pp. 1–10.

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record

- Fall 2026 CS 300 – Programming II (UW–Madison, ~60 students)
- Spring 2026 CS 642 – Introduction to Information Security (UW–Madison, ~40 students)
- Fall 2025 Computer Science 1 (Madison College, ~20 students)

Graduate Teaching Assistant (UW–Madison)

- CS 760 – Machine Learning (2 semesters)
- CS 642 – Introduction to Information Security (3 semesters)
- CS 320 – Data Science Programming II
- CS 300 – Programming II (2 semesters)
- CS 240 – Introduction to Discrete Mathematics

Additional Teaching Experience

- June 2023 – Project Assistant – redesigned assessments for UW–Madison’s ECE 454 (Mobile Computing Laboratory) to incorporate generative AI.
- August 2023
- June 2020 – Private Programming Tutor – introduced a middle-school student to Python programming through weekly one-on-one meetings and scaffolded projects.
- August 2021

Research Experience

- May 2023 – **Graduate Research Assistant**, *advised by Kassem Fawaz*, UW–Madison
- Present
- June 2025 – **Research Fellow**, *Data Privacy Lab*, UC Berkeley Center for Effective Global Action (CEGA)
- June 2026
- June 2021 – **Research Data Support Specialist**, *advised by Saumya Debray*, University of Arizona
- August 2021
- Sep. 2019 – **Undergraduate Research Assistant**, *advised by Stephen Kobourov*, University of Arizona
- May 2021

Awards and Honors

- 2026 FORC Travel Grant
- 2025 NeurIPS Travel Grant
- 2025 Madison College Teaching Fellowship
- 2021 University of Arizona College of Science Excellence in Undergraduate Research Award
- 2021 Phi Beta Kappa
- 2020 CRA Outstanding Undergraduate Researcher Honorable Mention
- 2020 Galileo Circle Scholarship
- 2019 Phi Theta Kappa Transfer Scholarship
- 2018 Phi Theta Kappa Honor Society

Invited and Research Talks

- 2026 Google Privacy Seminar. "Private Continual Counting of Unbounded Streams." July 15, 2026.
- 2026 FORC 2026. "Privacy, Prediction, and Allocation." June 5, 2026.

Campus Talks

- 2025 UW–Madison Department of Nuclear Engineering. Panelist for "Artificial Intelligence in Research: Ethical Challenges and Considerations". March 14, 2025.
- 2023 – Madison Security and Privacy Seminar. Discussion leader for:
 - 2024 ○ "A Researcher's Guide to Some Legal Risks of Security Research"
 - "Top Score on the Wrong Exam: On Benchmarking in Machine Learning for Vulnerability Detection"
 - "A Chronicle of the Application of Differential Privacy to the 2020 Census"
 - "What Does it Mean for a Language Model to Preserve Privacy?"
- 2023 CS 642 – Introduction to Information Security. Guest Lecture: "Introduction to Security & Privacy in Machine Learning." April 20, 2023.

Service

- Reviewer for ITCS 2026; *Stat*; SODA 2026; NeurIPS 2026; ICLR 2026; EuroVis 2021
- Volunteer mentor for incoming graduate students in Computer Sciences (2024, 2025)

Languages

- English (fluent)
- Mandarin (intermediate)